

Death from above
German Stukas (Ju-87s) return to their base in Northern France after attacking a British convoy in the English Channel. The Stuka divebomber played an important part in the German successes of 1940, combining with tanks and fast-moving motorized divisions in the "blitzkrieg" invasion of France.

sheer quantity of firepower available, from rapid-fire rifles and machine-guns to heavy artillery batteries, ensured massive losses in clashes between armies committed to victory at any cost. Soon, at least on the crucial Western Front, firepower triumphed over mobility. Largely static trench systems remained in place for more than three years because, with cavalry rendered ineffectual and few motor vehicles available, no offensive could advance fast enough to avoid being blocked by a counter-offensive. Infantry attacks across the no man's land between the trenches were often near-suicidal, and although a degree of mobility was restored in the last year of the war, casualties in offensives remained punishingly high.

MECHANIZED WAR

World War II was a more fluid and varied contest. Tanks and aircraft, marginal in their impact during World War I, became the determining factors in most of the campaigns of World War II. The Germans at first used them most successfully, having experimented with new fighting tactics during their military intervention in the Spanish Civil War (1936–39). Between 1939 and 1941 they conquered much of Europe in a series of lightning "blitzkrieg" campaigns, in which mechanized divisions and aircraft were used in combination to decisive shock effect. Japan made similar dramatic gains in Asia and the Pacific in 1941–42, with seaborne airpower playing a crucial role. The long fight by the Allies to press the war back in the opposite direction was a slower, gruelling process, in which ever greater quantities of weaponry were deployed. The tank battles fought between German and Soviet forces were large-scale attritional warfare, just as the trench battles of World War I had been. Allied bomber aircraft were used in thousands to devastate German and Japanese cities. Yet, as ever, there was no substitute for the courage and skills of individual fighting men, whether advancing from building to building in Stalingrad, jumping into action by parachute at Arnhem, making an opposed landing on a beach in the Pacific, or flying a bomber in broad daylight through German air defences.

AIR POWER

The use of aircraft was the biggest single innovation of warfare in this period. From early on it was realized that pilots had opportunities for individual heroism not possible on the land battlefield. High above the mass carnage of the trenches, the fighter pilots of World War I fought duels in which the outcome was decided by their sheer daring and skill in handling their aircraft. The most successful were hailed as "knights of the air", lionized by the press and in some cases accorded state funerals if they died, which many of them did.

The Spitfire and Hurricane pilots who defended their country in the Battle of Britain in 1940 were also glamourized as the "few" to whom so much was owed. But although individual skills were often at a premium in air combat, fliers generally fought a war of attrition in which their losses were proportionally as heavy as those in land fighting at its worst. Allied bomber crews flying over Germany in 1943 had a similar life expectancy to an infantryman at the battle of the Somme in 1916.

INFANTRY ELITES

Inevitably, the mass conscript armies of the two World Wars emphasized quantity over quality. In reaction, the idea of elite forces expected to outperform the average conscript infantryman came into being . Special "stormtrooper" units were created by the German army in World War I to spearhead offensives using specialist "infiltration" tactics. In World War II the US Airborne and Marines were promoted as special infantry formations with especially rigorous training and an aggressive attitude to combat.

DOOMED WARRIORS

In spite of attempts to keep traditional warrior virtues alive, they became problematic in this age of industrialized warfare fought by millions of civilians in uniform. Most nations went to war in 1914 inspired by notions of patriotic self-sacrifice and the glory of dying on the battlefield. But for many the spectacle of mass slaughter in the trenches permanently discredited any ideas of heroic warfare.

In the 1920s and 1930s the Japanese militarists, the Fascists in Italy, and the Nazis in Germany sought to revive a warrior ethic. The Nazi authorities certainly knew how to put on a magnificent military parade, yet there were no demonstrations of popular enthusiasm in Berlin to greet the oubreak of war in 1939 as there had been in 1914. The 1914–18 war was called "the war to end war", but this was something it signally failed to do. The dropping of atom bombs on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, which ended World War II in August 1945, however, suggested a future in which wars would simply be too costly to fight.





